

Every origin is first normalised to a [time, value] pair

INFER, None $\rightarrow$ [None, None]

0.5 $\rightarrow$ [0.5, None]

"molasses" $\rightarrow$ ["molasses", None]

[a, b] $\rightarrow$ [a, b]

Each slot is then completed independently: one left as None takes the caller's default for that slot.

time slot

every option names an instant

None	the caller's chain: ANCHOR $\rightarrow$ LAST $\rightarrow$ 0.0
a number	that number
tl.ANCHOR	the most recent anchor — an error if there is none
tl.LAST	the highest time recorded so far, $\pm\infty$ excepted
tl.VARIABLE	per variable: its own most recent time
a variable name	that variable's most recent time
a context name	its anchor, or its last row if it has none
anything else	an error

value slot

only a variable names a quantity

None	the caller's default: absolute — VARIABLE for ramp
a number	that number
tl.VARIABLE	per variable: its own last value †
a variable name	that variable's last value †
tl.ANCHOR, tl.LAST, a context name	refused — each names an instant, not a quantity
anything else	an error

† Bounded by the resolved time origin: the value in effect at the instant the new rows will occupy, not the variable's last value in the timeline as a whole. That is what lets an operation be interwoven and still see the state that precedes it.